

Is it the end of the road for licensed source software providers?

There has been a trend of major developers and providers of closed source software services acquiring open source software platforms and companies in order to stay relevant in the future. Though it is too early to write off closed source software completely, it is coming close to the point where OSS adoption will outpace growth in the proprietary software field.

Bhattacharyya adds that open source is a much more viable option for most of the IHVs and ISVs when it comes to infrastructure. Maintenance of proprietary software has become exorbitant and is not an economically viable option. Those in the open source software space embrace technology much faster, and allow more collaboration and hence innovation. Yes, we're not far from the stage at which OSS will become the default infrastructure software.

Businesses everywhere focus on improving profits by providing better solutions, and OSS has already shown its ability to do the same by cutting costs without compromising on the work quality.

Will emerging OSS create more jobs?

Open Source Jobs Report (2017) by Open Source Observatory says, "Hiring managers are increasingly looking for open source professionals, and two-thirds

of them say that the number of these specialists they hire will increase more than the hiring for other areas of their businesses. The main drivers are company growth (60 per cent), increasing use of open source technologies (42 per cent), and open source becoming core to the business (30 per cent)."

More companies shifting to OSS platforms will in every way lead to the creation of jobs. The widespread adoption of OSS will also lead to a call for better support services, resulting in more professionals required to carry out these tasks.

On achieving the 100 million live repositories milestone, GitHub posted on its blog: "Powering this number is an incredible community. Together, you're 31 million developers from nearly every country and territory in the world, collaborating across 1.1 billion contributions." This number of 31 million developers will only increase with time.

As OSS gets adopted by more institutions, the need for open source developers and those providing support will go up automatically. OSS implementation and onsite training will also lead to more job opportunities. And there will be more coding jobs as the ecosystem expands further. **END** 

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There is also the National Repository of Open Educational Resources (NROER)—a collaborative platform, which brings together everyone interested in school and teacher education (<https://nroer.gov.in/welcome>). Individuals like Kannan Moudgalya of IIT Bombay are very passionate in promoting FOSS in higher education as well as in schools, as Dr Nagarjuna points out.

The project called FOSSEE (Free and Open Source Software in Education) at IIT-Bombay (<https://fossee.in/about-us>) promotes the use of FOSS tools to improve the quality of education in India. Its stated aim has been articulated as follows: "We aim to reduce dependency on proprietary software in educational institutions. We encourage the use of FOSS tools through various activities to ensure commercial software is replaced by equivalent FOSS tools. We also develop new FOSS tools and upgrade existing tools to meet requirements in academia and research."

But even the best inputs could still result in disappointing outputs. In Dr Nagarjuna's view, the three main roadblocks preventing FOSS from entering academia in India are the syllabus, ignorant administrators and examinations.

Writing about the major challenges in a Spoken Tutorial project in Kerala, research scholar Sujithra Sankar said the Spoken Tutorial's integration process, lack of infrastructure,

budget and "the proprietary software-centric curriculum" were the biggest challenges faced (<https://acadpubl.eu/jsi/2018-118-7-9/articles/8/32.pdf> 7).

When asked what he would do to change this situation, Dr Nagarjuna said, "Create local community clubs at every street corner, and network them to expand the base of the pyramid."

The road to seeding FOSS in the Indian curriculum is long, and the challenges are many. But unless such issues are understood, and committed educationists come forth to lead, the change we need may never come about. **END** 

References

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